Keep Your Personas Front and Center with Persona Stories

Tired of endless revisions and second-guessing what users actually need? Persona stories keep your design process clear and focused. They act as smart placeholders for functionality, which helps you prioritize features, align your team, and make sure your work solves real problems for real people. Don't design for vague "users" anymore—with persona stories, you'll create intuitive experiences, streamline development, and stand out as the person who truly gets what users want.

How To Use This Template

Use this guide to understand the subtle but key differences between persona and user stories, and how to apply them. Plus, the worksheet at the end will help you write effective persona stories.

Ready to put your personas front and center? Let's go!

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A Brief History of Stories of Use

The most effective way to explore and communicate interaction design is through stories of use. These can range from simple lists of actions by the parties concerned to rich stories that use “the 5 Ws”: Who, what, where, when, and why? They can be text only, entirely visual, “as in the case of storyboards”, or a mixture of text and graphics. Persona and user stories are purely textual.

The most popular stories of use in software development are:

- **Use cases:** Devised by Ivar Jacobson in the 1980s.
- **User stories:** First described in the late 1990s and introduced with eXtreme Programming.

From a user-centered perspective, a significant problem with both is that they are usually written without detailed knowledge or understanding of who will use the solution. Instead, the focus is on roles, which leads to numerous unhelpful references such as “website visitors,” “customers,” and “registered users.” This approach can be described as role-centered design, which has almost nothing in common with user-centered design (although it is better than treating all users identically).

With the introduction of Agile in the early 2000s, user stories became the dominant stories of use in software development. They are brief descriptions of the functionality required for a solution, unlike use cases, which are usually very detailed. However, in Agile, it is an advantage to omit early detail since requirements may change during development.

Persona stories have the same general approach as user stories but are more user-centered since they are based on research-backed personas.

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Persona Stories vs User Stories

Both of these approaches to stories of use are intended to promise functionality. They are, in effect, scheduling placeholders. There needs to be enough detail so that:

- The development team has confidence that the functionality will be useful.
- They can roughly estimate how much effort implementation will involve.

User and persona stories usually fit on an index card or the digital equivalent.

User Stories

The most common form of a user story is:

> **User Story:** As a <role>, I want <goal>[, so that <outcome>]

Roles are usually responsibilities within an organization, but they can also be nondescript placeholders such as “user.” Goals represent the new state of the system that the user story aims to achieve. They should typically be user goals, but the author makes their best guess since users aren’t involved. The square brackets around “so that <outcome>” indicate that the clause is optional. It appears when the goal is not apparent. A non-apparent goal might be:

> “As a **user**, I want to **sort the list into alphabetical order** so that I can **locate duplicates**.”

Here, the user’s goal is to locate duplicates, but the system’s closest functionality is sorting the list alphabetically.

Persona Stories

A persona is a fictional representation of a group of users with similar needs and behaviors. Personas take one or more roles in a system (or organization) and are distilled from user research.

The first change we make in transitioning from user stories to persona stories is to replace the user story role with a persona. If a persona can take multiple roles, you may need to refer to both the persona and the role. The syntax of this isn’t too important, but you can use either “persona

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(role)" or "persona::role." The main point is that we understand much more about a persona than a role. If you focus on personas, it allows you to be more user-centric. Finally, a drawback of user stories is that they are written in the first person. This encourages the author to imagine what the role requires. In contrast, you write persona stories in the third person about the personas you've researched:

Persona Story: <Persona[::role]> wants <goal>[,so that <outcome>]

As with user stories, the square brackets indicate optional content. You usually only need the role when a persona has more than one or if it adds clarity. The "so that outcome" clause is still an option, but ideally, you would never need it because you will design solutions to meet users' needs. A persona story for the previous sorting task example would be:

"**Elizabeth** wants to **identify and remove duplicates**."

You can write persona stories alone; however, to get the most benefit, write them collaboratively—for example with the development and user experience teams.

Where to Learn More

Read William Hudson's article, *User Stories Don't Help Users: Introducing Persona Stories*.

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Quick Reference Table

Aspect	User Stories	Persona Stories
Definition	A straightforward, **first-person** description focused on **roles** (e.g., “user,” “manager,” etc.) and **goals**, intended to capture **what** a user needs and **why**.	Use **personas** instead of **roles** and you write them in the **third person**. A persona is a fictional person, **grounded in user research**, that represents a group of users with similar needs and behaviors.
Typical Format	**As a <role>, I want <goal>[, so that <outcome>]** The “so that” clause is optional and clarifies a non-apparent goal. **Example:** *“As a **user**, I want to **sort the list into alphabetical order** so that **I can locate duplicates**.”*	**<Persona[::role]> wants <goal>[, so that <outcome>]** The “so that” clause is still optional, but ideally unnecessary if the persona’s needs are well-understood. **Example:** *“**Elizabeth** wants to **identify and delete duplicates**.”*
Benefits	• Quickly capture **who** needs **what**. • Useful as **scheduling placeholders** for development. • Standardized format makes them **easy to create and understand**.	All the benefits of user stories, plus: • Are **user-centric** and focus on the specific, research-informed characteristics of the persona. • Encourage **empathetic design**, as you consider a realistic user’s background, motivations, and environment. • **Help teams remain aligned** on why certain features matter to real people

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Quick Reference Table

Aspect	User Stories	Persona Stories
Drawbacks	• First-person format can lead authors to **imagine** what the role requires, rather than basing it on real user data. • Roles can be **too generic** (customer, registered user, passenger) and may not reflect varied user motivations.	• Requires **more upfront research** (time and effort) to develop accurate personas. • If not well-maintained, personas can become **outdated** and lose credibility.
Example Stories	As a **user**, I want **advanced search filters** so that I can **narrow my search results quickly**. As a **shopper**, I want to **ask questions about products** so that I can **address any uncertainties before making a purchase**. As a **manager**, I want to **view a summary of daily sales** so that I can **evaluate the store's performance**.	**Kim (Marketing Manager)** wants to **narrow her search results quickly**. **Sam** wants to **ask questions about products** so that he can **address his uncertainties before making a purchase**. **Marta (Store Manager)** wants to **evaluate the store's performance**.

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Persona Story Worksheet

Designing for “users” is like cooking for “people”—too broad to be useful. Persona stories provide focus—they help you design for real individuals with clear goals, challenges, and motivations. Use this template to create persona stories that truly reflect your users’ needs.

1

Use the Persona Story Format

Persona Story: <Persona[::role]> wants <goal>[, so that <outcome>]

Example: *“Elizabeth wants to identify and remove duplicate entries, so that her reports remain accurate and reliable.”*

Now, write your persona story for an important feature in your project:

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Ensure Clarity & User-Centeredness

Ask yourself:

- Does it focus on a specific persona, not a role or generic “user”/“customer”?
- Is the goal framed around the persona’s real-world needs?
- If the outcome is included, does it add useful context?

Example Rewrite:

“A user wants to clean up their dataset.” (Too vague!)

✓ *“Elizabeth wants to identify and remove duplicate entries so that her reports remain accurate and reliable.”*

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Is It a Persona Story or Just Another User Story?

Use this checklist to make sure you've written a **persona story**—not just a generic user story:

- ○ Does it focus on a specific persona with a name, background, and real needs—rather than just a role or generic "user"/ "customer"?
- ○ Is it based on actual user research rather than assumptions about what a role might need?
- ○ Is it written in the third person (e.g., "Alex wants..." instead of "As a user, I want...")?
- ○ Does it clearly explain the persona's goal and why it matters to them?
- ○ Would a real person recognize themselves in this story, or does it sound vague and system-driven?

If you answered **yes** to all of these, you've got a solid persona story! If not, refine it by focusing on **real people**, **real needs**, **and real context**.

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Collaborate and Refine

You should develop persona stories with both development and UX teams to ensure they accurately reflect user needs.

- Who should review this persona story for accuracy?

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- What feedback could improve it?

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Do You Want to Learn More?

Learn how to use this template to its full potential in our online course **Personas and User Research: Design Products and Services People Need and Want.** Sign up for it today and learn how to create effective personas from scratch if you're not already enrolled.

Beginner Course

In this course, you will:

- **Get excited** to create products and services people actually love—**without the guesswork**. Expanding requirements cause **47% of projects** to overspend, launch late, or fail altogether. When you design for a persona, you get focus on what truly matters and **solve the real problems** people have. Fewer problems, more smiles—**more smiles, more profit**.
- **Make yourself invaluable** when you can transform raw research into **powerful personas** that turn ideas into user-centered solutions that **smash business goals**. AI can't replace these timeless, human-centered skills, and you will **become the go-to expert** on your team who can help customers **get what they truly want**.
- **Gain confidence and credibility** as you learn the simple step-by-step method to create effective personas—complete with templates that **turn knowledge into real-world results**. Get to grips with observations, triangulation, and grounded theory, distill your findings with affinity diagrams, and pour it all into **personas that work**. Access real user research in the optional **course project**, and bring your new skills to life with a portfolio piece that'll open up **exciting and fulfilling career opportunities**.

Learn more about this course

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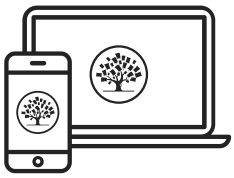

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